

SHAHNAMEH TD

README 02 — GAMEPLAY, VISUAL UX, AND REPLAYABILITY

Senior Game-Design Specification

1. PRODUCT PROMISE

Shahnameh TD should feel like an illustrated heroic tale that the player actively defends.

The player must feel intelligent and heroic:

```
I saw the pressure.  
I prepared a defense.  
I moved my champion at the right moment.  
I rescued a region before it collapsed.  
I adapted my build.  
I defeated a mythic ordeal.  
I discovered a new possibility.  
I want to replay immediately.
```

The first battle must be easy to understand. The fiftieth run must still create interesting choices.

2. DESIGN PILLARS

2.1 Readable tactics on a phone

At normal mobile zoom, the player must identify within seconds:

- enemy entrances
- enemy paths
- build pads
- tower types
- hero position
- objective location
- threatened region
- corruption severity
- boss telegraph
- off-screen emergency

Decorative art supports the battlefield. It never competes with it.

2.2 Active tower defense

The player does more than place towers and wait.

The player:

- positions a hero
- activates skills
- cleanses corruption
- rescues hijacked towers
- uses regional tools
- selects Fate cards
- reacts to boss mechanics
- changes strategy during Pardeh Breaks

2.3 Replayability through decisions

Variation must change the player's strategy, not only increase enemy health.

A new run can change:

- hero
- route branch
- build-pad priorities
- Fate cards
- relics
- optional objectives
- Forge hybrids
- rival Memory Div
- Zahhak Pact
- Blood Oath
- map modifier
- Daily Tale seed

2.4 Cultural coherence

Use Shahnameh identity respectfully and consistently.

Avoid:

- generic Western-fantasy castles
- random runes
- fake Persian writing
- costume mixing without narrative reason

- visual ornament that damages clarity

2.5 Fair engagement

Players return because they enjoyed mastery, discovery, and improvement.

Avoid:

- paid power
 - grind walls
 - punitive streak loss
 - confusing currencies
 - manipulative urgency
 - forced battle interruptions
-

3. FIRST 60 SECONDS

The first minute teaches by doing.

1. Show one entrance, one route, one gate, Rostam, and two build pads.
2. Highlight an Archer Tower card.
3. Let the player place the tower.
4. Send a small readable enemy group.
5. Show that Rostam can intercept a leak.
6. Introduce one subtle corruption warning.
7. Award enough Sacred Fire to cleanse it.
8. End the first wave with a satisfying reward pulse.
9. Preview the next threat.

Do not introduce every future system immediately.

The first battle should not require the player to understand:

- Morale
- Farr
- Forge hybrids
- complex relic combinations
- rewind
- Qanat movement
- Blood Oaths
- Zahhak Pacts
- Memory Divs

Introduce complexity in layers.

4. MINUTE-TO-MINUTE GAMEPLAY LOOP

```
read the next threat
-> decide whether to build, upgrade, or save
-> move the hero toward the most dangerous pressure
-> protect or cleanse a region
-> react to a leak, elite, hijack, or objective
-> collect rewards
-> preview the next wave
```

The player should face a meaningful decision approximately every 15–30 seconds without feeling overwhelmed.

5. FIVE-WAVE STRUCTURE

Every five waves, open a **Pardeh Break**.

```
review the run
-> choose one of three Fate cards
-> optionally reroll
-> accept or decline an optional objective
-> select one strategic action
-> inspect the next pressure
-> continue
```

A Pardeh Break should usually take 20–40 seconds.

It should feel like turning a page in an illustrated epic, not leaving the game to manage a spreadsheet.

6. CORE RESOURCES

6.1 Gold

Gold is the immediate tower-defense currency.

Use it for:

- building towers
- upgrading towers

- repair
- repositioning where allowed
- selected tactical actions

The player should regularly face tension between safety now and preparation for later waves.

6.2 Gate integrity

Enemies reaching the destination damage the player's gate or Lives.

Feedback must include:

- clear impact sound
- short visual pulse
- direction indicator
- damage amount or readable state change
- post-defeat explanation

6.3 Sacred Fire

Sacred Fire is the signature anti-corruption resource.

Use it for:

- cleansing threatened regions
- activating braziers
- preventing collapse
- recovering some hijacked towers
- enabling certain hero skills
- powering Sacred Fire tower builds
- activating map-specific actions

Sacred Fire must feel important but usable. If players hoard it forever, the system is too punishing. If they spend it without thinking, the system is too generous.

6.4 Morale

Morale represents the confidence of the heroic defense.

Morale can affect:

- tower responsiveness
- defensive aura
- objective reward
- comeback potential
- specific card synergies

Keep Morale visually secondary until it becomes relevant.

6.5 Farr

Farr represents heroic glory and long-term mastery.

Use Farr for:

- account progression
- heroic unlock paths
- collection milestones
- mastery rewards
- cosmetic recognition

Farr must not become a paid power currency.

7. REGIONAL LIGHT AND CORRUPTION

Divide each map into readable regions.

Region state	Visual language	Gameplay meaning
Stable	warm light, clean terrain, teal accents	normal operation
Pressured	subtle cold veins and warning icon	respond soon
Critical	stronger charcoal-violet corruption and alert sound	immediate action needed
Collapsed	transformed terrain and unmistakable state change	enemy advantage, tower weakness, route pressure, or hijack danger

Corruption must be:

- visible before punishment
- predictable enough to plan around
- dramatic enough to demand action
- recoverable through skilled play
- stronger in later maps without becoming arbitrary

8. TOWER HIJACKING

Tower hijacking is a signature threat.

A fair hijack sequence:

```
visible corruption signal
-> warning sound
-> dark tendrils approach tower
-> rescue window
-> hijacked tower changes silhouette
-> player uses cleanse or recovery action
-> satisfying purification pulse
```

Never silently disable a tower.

Early maps use generous recovery windows. Late maps compress the timing and add competing pressure.

9. HERO CONTROL AND SACRED TETHER

Heroes are active battlefield units.

Rostam begins as:

- frontline fighter
- boss responder
- leak interceptor
- emergency defender
- Sacred Tether amplifier

A hero should solve problems towers cannot solve alone:

- hold a breach
- intercept a runner
- interrupt a boss action
- protect a purification attempt
- activate a regional point
- strengthen nearby towers
- recover from an unexpected route change

Do not require constant micro-management. Hero movement should be strategic, not exhausting.

10. STARTER TOWERS

Tower	Main role	Strength	Weakness	Visual silhouette
Archer Tower	fast single-target damage	reliable early damage	weaker against armor and large groups	timber platform and teal canopy
Sacred Fire Tower	burn and corruption support	purification synergy	weaker raw damage without setup	stone brazier and warm flame
Heavy Tower	armor break and impact	strong against brutes and clustered targets	slow attack rate	thick masonry and heavy launcher
Control Tower	slow, stagger, path control	buys time and stabilizes pressure	lower direct damage	wind-and-qanat-inspired utility form

Each tower must communicate its job before the player reads detailed statistics.

11. ADVANCED TOWERS AND FORGE HYBRIDS

Hybrid	Intended playstyle
Flame Archer	rapid burn stacking
Volcano Ram	heavy explosive anti-armor pressure
Qanat Weaver	slow, reposition, route support
Derafsh Bastion	morale and defensive aura
Azar Oracle	Sacred Fire economy and purification

Forge hybrids should reward intentional builds. They should not appear randomly without explanation.

12. HERO ROSTER

Hero	Role	Playstyle
Rostam	frontline champion	direct, readable, powerful, ideal starting hero
Zal	tactical support	foresight, rescue, range, Simorgh-linked utility
Gordafarid	mobile defender	gate defense, rapid response, resilient positioning

Hero	Role	Playstyle
Esfandiyar	armored frontline	high durability and disciplined hold-the-line play
Sohrab	high-risk aggression	powerful pressure with emotional narrative weight
Kaveh	morale leader	defensive rally and Derafsh synergy
Simorgh	rare support presence	rescue, purification, and dramatic recovery

Start with one hero. Add the others only after their tactical identity is clear.

13. EIGHT MAPS

Map	Scale	Grid	Main tactical lesson
Khan 1 — Lion and Rakhsh	Medium	32 × 18	basics, corruption warning, hero movement
Khan 2 — Desert of Thirst	Medium	36 × 20	resource pressure and exposed lanes
Khan 3 — Azhdaha Canyon	Medium-large	40 × 22	split routes and boss arena control
Khan 4 — Sorceress Feast	Medium-large	42 × 24	illusion routes and information clarity
Khan 5 — Olad Camp	Large	48 × 27	branching priorities and staged fronts
Khan 6 — Arzhang Fortress	Large	52 × 30	siege sectors and breach defense
Khan 7 — White Div Cavern	Very large	56 × 32	visibility pressure and chamber activation
Damavand Binding	Very large	64 × 36	multi-objective finale and anchor control

Large-map rule

Large does not mean empty.

Use:

- staged sector activation
- minimap
- camera anchors
- threat-jump button
- off-screen warnings
- short travel transitions

- clear primary and secondary fronts
- controlled route reveals

The player should feel scale without fighting the camera.

14. BOSS DESIGN RULES

Every boss needs:

1. a readable entrance
2. a recognizable silhouette
3. at least one new battlefield question
4. visible telegraphs
5. punishments that teach rather than confuse
6. a phase shift or meaningful escalation
7. a satisfying defeat state

Avoid health-sponge bosses.

Boss identities

Boss	Tactical question
Lion of the First Khan	Can the player use Rostam and towers together?
Manifestation of Thirst	Can the player manage scarce relief and exposed paths?
Azhdaha	Can the player prepare for emergence, fire, and split pressure?
Sorceress	Can the player read deception and adapt after a reveal?
Olad	Can the player survive a human champion without treating him as a monster?
Arzhang Div	Can the player defend siege sectors under summons and slams?
Div-e Sepid	Can the player maintain control under blindness and heavy pressure?
Zahhak	Can the player bind multiple anchors while surviving a staged finale?

15. REPLAYABILITY SYSTEMS

15.1 Fate cards

Offer three cards during Pardeh Breaks.

A strong card changes decisions:

- tower specialization
- Sacred Fire use
- hero positioning
- corruption timing
- objective risk
- Forge strategy
- recovery strategy

Avoid cards that are only minor percentage increases.

15.2 Relics

Relics create longer build arcs.

A relic should:

- support a recognizable playstyle
- combine with cards
- create a story-like discovery
- avoid becoming mandatory
- remain readable in one short description

15.3 Route branches

Between encounters, offer route decisions:

- safer reward
- elite hunt
- story node
- Forge opportunity
- relic discovery
- corrupted shortcut
- healing or repair
- high-risk Blood Oath

15.4 Blood Oaths

Blood Oaths are optional skill tests.

Examples:

- survive without selling towers
- finish with a protected region
- accept stronger elites

- defeat a boss under a time condition
- limit the use of Sacred Fire
- protect an optional objective

Rewards should be meaningful but not required for normal progression.

15.5 Zahhak Pacts

Zahhak Pacts offer tempting power with visible cost.

Examples:

- gain immediate Gold but begin with one Pressured region
- improve a tower family but strengthen one elite type
- gain a relic but reduce cleanse efficiency
- gain a reroll but add a corruption event

The cost must be clear before acceptance.

15.6 Memory Div

A Memory Div remembers a previous successful pattern and returns as a rival modifier.

Examples:

- resists the player's most-used tower family
- attacks the most-protected region
- forces a different route priority
- mirrors a previously favored strategy

Memory Divs should encourage adaptation, not invalidate a player's collection.

15.7 Daily Tale

Daily Tale uses a validated seed:

- one map
- one hero or limited hero pool
- predefined modifiers
- fair objective
- fixed card pool
- score or mastery target

Daily Tale should support competition without forcing daily attendance.

15.8 Endless Mode

Endless Mode is for players who want mastery after the authored campaign.

Scale:

- enemy combinations
- route pressure
- corruption timing
- elite modifiers
- boss echoes
- optional objectives

Do not scale only enemy health.

16. UI HIERARCHY

Always visible

- Lives or gate integrity
- Gold
- Sacred Fire
- current wave
- pause
- speed
- hero portrait
- hero HP and energy
- hero skill
- tower cards
- selected-object context

Contextual

- cleanse
- Qanat
- Forge
- purge
- repair
- sell
- reposition
- tower details
- objective details
- boss phase details
- Morale and Farr expansion
- relic explanation

Alert priority

1. gate danger
2. tower hijack
3. regional collapse
4. boss telegraph
5. objective warning
6. normal wave update
7. reward notification

Never let decorative alerts hide urgent gameplay.

17. VISUAL UX RULES

- Use clear warm-versus-cold contrast for Stable and Corrupted regions.
 - Reserve the strongest glow for important actions.
 - Keep enemy route contrast stronger than decorative terrain contrast.
 - Make enemy classes readable by silhouette, not tiny accessories.
 - Keep bosses visually impressive but tactically clear.
 - Use restrained screen shake.
 - Allow players to reduce flashes and particles.
 - Use localization-safe UI areas.
 - Avoid text baked into image assets.
-

18. ACCESSIBILITY

Include:

- UI scale
- high-contrast mode
- color-safe corruption indicators
- reduced flashes
- reduced particles
- reduced screen shake
- music, ambience, UI, and SFX volume sliders
- subtitles for narrative content
- readable font sizing
- vibration toggle
- pause support
- speed controls
- clear touch feedback
- left-handed layout option if practical

Do not rely only on red-versus-green color differences.

19. RETENTION WITHOUT MANIPULATION

A successful replay loop:

```
finish run
-> understand the result
-> see one meaningful reward
-> discover one new possibility
-> choose replay or next route in one tap
```

Avoid:

- too many result screens
- long reward animations
- forced store visits
- energy timers blocking play
- streak loss anxiety
- daily chores
- confusing currency chains

20. KHAN 1 VERTICAL-SLICE ACCEPTANCE GATE

Khan 1 is approved only when:

- the first tower placement feels immediate
- the route is readable
- Rostam movement matters
- all four towers have distinct roles
- Sacred Fire is understood
- corruption is noticed before collapse
- tower hijack is fair
- the Lion boss changes behavior
- frame rate is stable on target devices
- a defeat explains the failure
- replay requires one tap
- testers voluntarily replay

Do not build seven polished maps around an unproven first battle.